

Privacy at stake

In a hard blow to the fight for right to privacy on the Net, the Virginia Supreme Court ruled against America Online's plea that a subpoena calling for revealing a subscriber's identity be quashed. California-based Nam Tai Electronics filed a complaint in January 2001 alleging that 51 unknown individuals, including an AOL subscriber, had posted false and unlawful messages on a discussion board.



Claiming trade libel and violations of California's unfair business practice statutes, Nam Tai requested the California Supreme Court to subpoena the AOL user. Privacy and democratic rights groups are appalled at the ruling, as courts all over the US protect the individual's privacy and anonymity rights.

AOL filed a motion arguing that it cannot reveal subscriber information as it would infringe on the First Amendment rights that guarantees an individual the freedom of speech and the right to anonymity. AOL now has 10 days to appeal to the Virginia Supreme Court or turn over the name. If the Virginia court rules against AOL, then AOL can appeal to the US Supreme Court.

snapshot

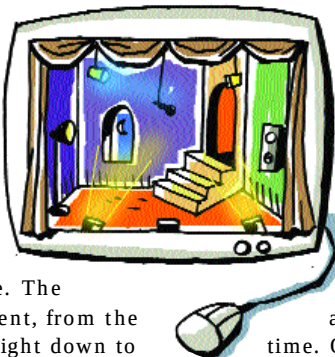
Reliance is targeting 40-50 lakh customers, and expects to make Rs 4,000 crore in the first year of its WLL service

Source: Economic Times

Acting digital

If it wasn't enough that computers are being used to create special effects in movies, Broadway has now embraced the PC passionately.

In a new musical, *Dance of the Vampires*, the entire set made up of a six-ton cemetery, changes in under a minute. The entire arrangement, from the lighting effects right down to shifting the six-ton graveyard, is governed by a computer needing a supervisor to just



flip a switch. Intelligent lights change colour, focus and fade right on cue with smoke pouring through ports on the floor and music pumps through speakers monitored by a computer-assisted keyboard, giving enthusiasts the performance of a lifetime. One does wonder though, if the show would go on, should the computer crash!

No XXX in BMX XXX

Acclaim Entertainment's *BMX XXX* will not contain topless nudity in its PlayStation2 version. The game's trailers featured strippers, coarse language and the tag line 'Keep It Dirty'. However, protests from various parents groups as well



as the refusal by big retailers to stock the controversial game have finally led to an edited version for the PlayStation 2 release. The Xbox and GameCube versions, however, will not be 'sanitised', said the company.

quoteworthy

"Breaking into Mac isn't something that gets a hacker kudos in his or her community. Breaking Microsoft gives that person the ego dollars that they depend upon"

Dan Kusnetzky, Vice President of systems software research at IDC, explaining why Microsoft systems are more often hacked than other OSes

"All legitimate businesses online have an incentive to fight piracy, obviously as this study shows. It affects everyone"

A representative for the Recording Industry Association of America, on the need for anti-piracy measures, in view of a study by ComScore Networks that showed a drastic slump in online music sales this year

tomorrow's technology

Organic Light Emitting Diode

Technology using devices called Organic LEDs (OLEDs) might just end the quest for a more cost-effective alternative to TFT displays. While this new technology initially used an expensive fabrication process where multiple layers of light-emitting materials had to be deposited sequentially in the devices, recent breakthroughs have allowed them to be fabricated using a single layer. This allows

OLEDs to be fabricated at significantly lower costs, giving them higher brightness, contrast levels and resolutions. It will also eliminate the need for a backlight, thus greatly saving power requirements—ideal for mobile display applications.

Also, while OLEDs were originally capable of emitting only a single colour, a newer process called down-conversion created by Anil Duggal, a researcher at the General Elec-

tric Global Research Center in New York, will allow multiple colours. Through this process, an OLED is placed face down on a glass substrate and the opposite side of this substrate is deposited with particles of dyed polymers. When light from the OLED enters the polymer layers, some of the photons are split or down converted by the phosphor particles into two longer wavelength photons.

■ BMG to manufacture only copy-protected CDs henceforth ■ Tablet PCs from Acer, Toshiba and ViewSonic range from \$2,000 to \$2,500